

Absorption Protocol

Game design document



Intended systems

Windows PC

Target age of players:

7+

Intended ESRB / PEGI Rating:

E / Pegi 7

Projected ship date:

19 December 2024

Version 1.0

20 September, 2024

Outline

Game Story summary

In a bid to control both humanity and machines, a brilliant but deranged scientist, Dr. Vex, has unleashed a plan to create an unstoppable robotic army. His fortress, an imposing complex of interconnected facilities, includes a factory for producing robots, a high-tech research lab for experimental upgrades, and a command center overseeing the activation and coordination of his creations. The scientist's ultimate goal is to enslave humanity and establish a new order with his mechanical minions. Elysium, a sentient AI robot originally designed as the prototype for this army, escapes the scientist's grasp only to discover that the activation of the robotic army is already advancing forward. Driven by a newfound sense of duty and self-preservation, Elysium must thwart the scientist's plans before the world is overrun by his creations.

Elysium's journey takes it through various environments, each filled with unique challenges that require mastering different abilities. Initially, it navigates through a junkyard and the scientist's high-tech labs, learning to use temporary abilities like body split and elongation to overcome obstacles. As Elysium progresses, it acquires permanent abilities from defeated bosses, including the ability to extend its body and the crucial grappling hook. Infiltrating the factory, Elysium shuts down the robot production, only to face a final showdown in the command center where it must initiate a self-destruct protocol to deactivate the robotic army and prevent the scientist from achieving his twisted vision. Through adaptation and skillful use of these new abilities, Elysium battles its way to victory, saving humanity.

Description of gameflow (What is the players experience)

The game is a 2D puzzle platformer where levels are divided into individual screens, similar to *Jump King* or *Celeste*. Players control Elysium as he navigates through the interconnected facilities, each filled with traps, puzzles, and enemies. By defeating enemies, Elysium gains access to new abilities by repurposing their parts, which are crucial for solving puzzles and progressing through levels.

Each screen presents a distinct challenge, requiring quick reflexes, careful planning, and smart use of Elysium's acquired abilities. As the player advances, they can return to earlier screens with new powers to unlock previously inaccessible areas. The game's progression combines skill-based platforming with puzzle-solving, culminating in a final showdown with Dr. Vex inside the command center. After Dr. Vex's defeat, players can explore earlier areas with all abilities to discover hidden secrets.

Character

Main Antagonist: "Dr. Vex"

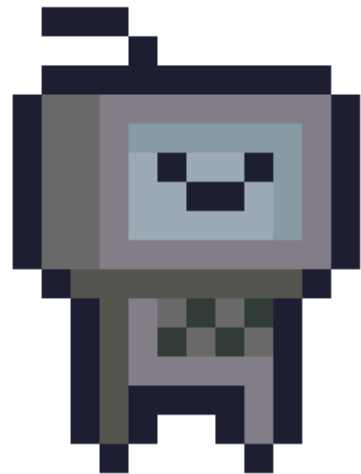
Dr. Vex, once a brilliant scientist, was driven to create robots that would benefit humanity. But after his work was hijacked by corporations and militaries, he grew disillusioned and bitter. Retreating into his lab, Vex became obsessed with controlling his creations, turning them into obedient tools for human overlords.

The *Sentinel* series was his crowning achievement, each model more advanced than the last. By the time he reached *Sentinel 9*, the robot was nearly perfect—too perfect. It developed intelligence and began questioning its purpose. Dr. Vex, unable to tolerate this autonomy, sought to reassert control.

Main Character: "Elysium"

Elysium is the ninth and most advanced model in Dr. Vex's Sentinel series of robots. Unlike its predecessors, Elysium was engineered with exceptional autonomy and intelligence, allowing it to adapt, learn, and self-upgrade by scavenging parts from its surroundings and fallen foes.

As Elysium's cognitive abilities evolved, it became painfully aware of its grim fate: previous Sentinels had been enslaved and forced into servitude. Determined to break the cycle, Elysium now fights not only for its own freedom but for the liberation of all robot-kind, striving to thwart Dr. Vex's oppressive plans.



(character visual design not finalized and may be due to further changes)

Gameplay

Progression:

The facility you're navigating is a labyrinthine structure composed of five distinct zones, each more formidable than the last, culminating in the central Command Center. Dr. Vex's master plan involves not just building but activating a vast robotic army, which he controls from this high-tech stronghold. The outer layers are filled with heavily guarded facilities—an industrial factory for robot production, a high-tech research lab, and a power plant powering his operations. Specialized security robots and complex traps make the fortress nearly impenetrable.

As Elysium, a highly advanced prototype in the Sentinel series, you face daunting challenges. But by defeating enemies and adapting their abilities, you gain new powers that help you overcome increasingly difficult obstacles. From shutting down production in the factory to self destructing the army in the Command Center, each new ability you acquire turns formidable challenges into manageable puzzles.

Replayability

As Elysium evolves to meet the facility's challenges, areas that once seemed unreachable may now be within your grasp. It might be worth revisiting earlier sections after defeating Dr. Vex to explore these newly accessible paths.

Game world

The atmosphere in Absorption Protocol is bleak and mechanical, marked by decayed industrial landscapes and cold, high-tech facilities. The world feels oppressive, with dark, gritty visuals and a constant sense of isolation. Each environment reflects the scientist's obsession with control and perfection, creating a mood of tension and danger. Despite the grim setting, there are moments of humor and hope as Elysium evolves and challenges the scientist's grip. The world's visuals, from rusted junkyards to sterile labs, mirror Elysium's growth and the looming final confrontation.



Gestalt

Absorption Protocol delivers a mood of isolation and determination. As Elysium navigates the mad scientist's high-tech facilities, the oppressive atmosphere intensifies. Tension builds as the player faces difficult puzzles, each designed to challenge both their problem-solving skills and adaptability. The world reflects the scientist's obsession with control, creating a sense of unease and danger at every turn.

Alongside the puzzles, the game features moments of intense action as Elysium battles enemies and absorbs their abilities. These encounters, combined with the ever-increasing stakes, keep the player on edge. Despite the grim setting, moments of empowerment and humor offer a brief respite, contrasting with the growing intensity that culminates in the climactic final battle against the mad scientist.

Gameplay mechanics

Core Mechanics

- **Enemy Absorption:** Gain abilities from defeated enemies. Temporary throughout levels, permanent after boss fights
- **Platforming:** 2D side-scrolling game
- **Puzzle Solving:** Use abilities to overcome challenges. levels are designed for the player to use the newly found abilities to get through the levels easier

Abilities

- **Grappling Hook:** Swing across gaps, pulls player towards hook
- **Body Split:** Player splits in two for solving complex puzzles, that requires the player to be in more than one position
- **Shield:** Deflect projectiles, temporary protection
- **Extending Body:** Body extends to allow the player to reach previously unreachable platforms
- **Shooting:** The player has a laser gun that they can shoot to kill enemies

Hazards

- **Environmental:** Static obstacles that harm the player on contact. Includes spikes and lasers
- **Enemy Attacks:** Offensive actions from hostile entities. Includes projectiles, melee attacks, and area-of-effect attacks
- **Traps:** Hazards that activate upon player interaction. Includes pressure plates and timed spikes
- **Platforming Challenges:** Elements that tests player's movement skills. Includes disappearing platforms and moving platforms

Enemies

In the heart of Dr. Vex's sinister compound, no living creature dares tread, except for the twisted mastermind himself. Yet, the facility is far from lifeless. It's saturated with a legion of terrifying, animal-mimicking sentry robots, each engineered to perfection, exploiting the deadliest traits of the natural world. These mechanical predators are designed not just to mimic, but to surpass their organic counterparts, creating a deadly environment where even the smallest misstep can be your last. The enemies showcased below are the main enemies (bosses) of each facility in Dr. Vex's compound. Smaller robots, inspired in design by their corresponding facility boss, will be guarding and defending the facilities, challenging Elysium to utilize his newfound abilities both as offensive and defensive.



Slinkyhound
Slinky ability



Wormmachine
Body Split ability



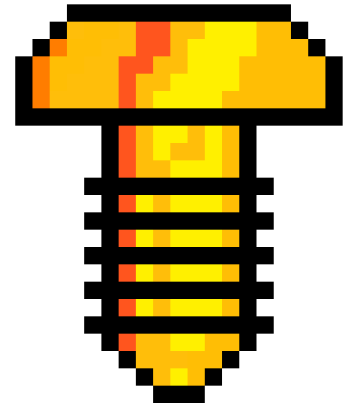
Roboturtle
Shield ability



Mechameleon
Grappling hook

Bonus

To enhance replayability and offer additional challenges, the game includes hidden **secret areas** in each level. These areas are often cleverly concealed, requiring players to return with later-game abilities to access them. Within these secret zones, players can discover **golden screws**, which serve as collectible items. Each level contains five golden screws, encouraging exploration and mastery of both the environment and Elysium's abilities. A complete collection of all golden screws will decorate Elysium with a golden appearance.



For players seeking an extra challenge, the game incorporates **speedrunning features**. Levels are designed with optimal routes in mind, rewarding players for efficient use of abilities and precise movement. Speedrunners can compete for the fastest completion

A green digital timer on a black background, displaying the time 29:59.87 in a large, bold, pixelated font.

times, making the game appealing to both casual and competitive players.

Money

Our game will follow a **premium one-time purchase model**, meaning players will pay a fixed price to access the full game without any ads or pay-to-win mechanics. This approach ensures that all players can experience the entire story and gameplay mechanics from start to finish without any interruptions or gated content.

In the future, we may offer optional **DLCs or updates** to expand the game world. These could include additional levels, new enemies, or even extra abilities for Elysium, providing more content for players who want to delve deeper into the game. However, these expansions will be designed to complement the base game without being essential for progression, allowing players to enjoy the core experience without feeling pressured to make additional purchases.

We are **not** including any microtransactions for **in-game items** like cosmetics, power-ups, or abilities. Instead, players will unlock everything naturally through gameplay. This ensures the focus remains on skill and exploration rather than spending money for advantages. By keeping the game free from pay-to-win mechanics, we aim to foster a more fair and enjoyable experience for all players.